

fridayReview

THE HINDU

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THE QUEEN OF POP MAKES A COMEBACK

Madonna performs at Coachella, drops a single and announces an album **p3**

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Benaras follows its own unique rhythm. At sunrise, the Ganga comes alive with the gentle lifting of the mist, as the boats criss-cross its waters, hundreds of seagulls flutter above the surface and people gather along its ghats. By dusk, the river quietyens, turning into an expanse of varied hues of twilight, occasionally illuminated by the flicker of the floating *diyas*. Within this eternal cycle of faith and time, the Sankat Mochan Sangeet Samaroh has evolved over a century.

As night deepens, all roads leading to the Sankat Mochan temple grow thick with traffic. Wading through them is a challenge. But when you finally step into the temple, the world seems to pause. Melody and rhythm fill the air, blending seamlessly with chants and prayers.

Though the Samaroh takes place within the hallowed precincts of a 16th-century temple, founded by Tulsidas after his vision of Hanuman, it is not merely a devotional gathering. Initially conceived as a modest cultural offering, it sought to celebrate the musical soul of the ancient city. “My grandfather launched it, my father carried it forward, and I eventually took on the



responsibility of nurturing it,” says curator and organiser Prof. Vishwambhar Nath Mishra, who belongs to the lineage of Sant Tulsidas and is popularly known as the Mahant.

Over the years, the Samaroh has evolved into one of the country’s most distinctive music festivals, shaping Benaras’ identity as a vital seat of Hindustani classical music.

By framing performances as *haazri* – an act of marking attendance in Hanuman’s durbar – the festival infuses music with spiritual gravitas. “It not only deepens the musicians’ engagement with their art but also draws the audience into an immersive experience. Beyond serving as a cherished stage for legendary artistes, the Samaroh also supports local talent and sustains gharana traditions. More importantly, it democratises access to classical music by opening its doors to all, free of charge,” says the Mahant, a professor at the Banaras Hindu University and a skilled pakhawaj player, who often accompanies musicians at the Samaroh.

With a gentle smile, he adds, “It is important to understand sound more as an artiste and a rasika than as an organiser.”

The Mahant’s belief in



Musical confluence The audience seated in the temple courtyard; Pt. Sajan Mishra performing with son Swaransh; and the Ganga ghats.

PHOTOS: RAVI DEO MISHRA & ISTOCK

vibration and energy. I am the third generation in my family to perform here, so it is deeply special,” says Ishaan Ghosh, grandson of tabla maestro Nikhil Ghosh and son of tabla exponent Nayan Ghosh.

“Indian classical music has never allowed religion to become a boundary – Bade Ghulam Ali Khan sang ‘Hari om tat sat’ and Pt. Jasraj rendered ‘Allah tero naam’. As musicians, we must recognise and celebrate this aspect of art.”

The festival closes on a euphoric note with Pt. Sajan Mishra’s (of the iconic Rajan-Sajan Mishra duo) *haazri*. It is nearly 6.30 a.m. when he takes the stage, and the audience has been waiting expectantly to hear the son of the soil. Born and raised in Benaras, the brothers made their debut in 1968 at this very Samaroh. Accompanied by son Swaransh on vocal support, Pt Sajan Mishra demonstrates how *taalim* (training) and *tehzeeb* (values) can preserve music in its most purest and pious form. As the summer sun grows brighter, the veteran casually pulls out his coolers from a bag, slips them on, and continues with a series of requests from the audience.

“*Yeh prem ki nagari hai* (this is a city of love). Since the time of the Vedas, Benaras has been the capital of art and literature. But the city’s music truly began in kirtans, and then evolved under the influence of folk styles. It is the only gharana where vocal, instrumental and dance co-exist. Unfortunately, over time it came to be associated only with thumris and Kathak. My brother Rajan and I strove hard to revive its khayal tradition and present to the world its most treasured works,” says the Delhi-based Pt. Sajan Mishra, choosing to sit since he had not slept the night before due to the early-morning concert. “Age can be a deterrent when keeping to a tight schedule, but I would like to keep flowing resiliently like the Ganga,” he says with a glint in his eyes.

Gently flow the inclusive notes

At the 103-year-old Sankat Mochan Sangeet Samaroh by the Ganga, artistes of all faiths mark their presence at Hanuman’s durbar

music as a shared experience comes alive during the Samaroh, which is held every April after Hanuman Jayanti. Devotees sit around the sanctum reciting the *Hanuman Chalisa*, while music lovers occupy the entire courtyard, listening through the night to

vocalists and instrumentalists. Some in the audience doze off on the dhurries, and leave only when the last note fades into the early-morning aarti. For many, like the students from the music departments of Banaras Hindu University and Allahabad University, staying awake through all five nights of the Samaroh has become an annual ritual. “This is the best practical lesson in music that we can get, and as learners we can’t afford to miss it,” says Shraddha

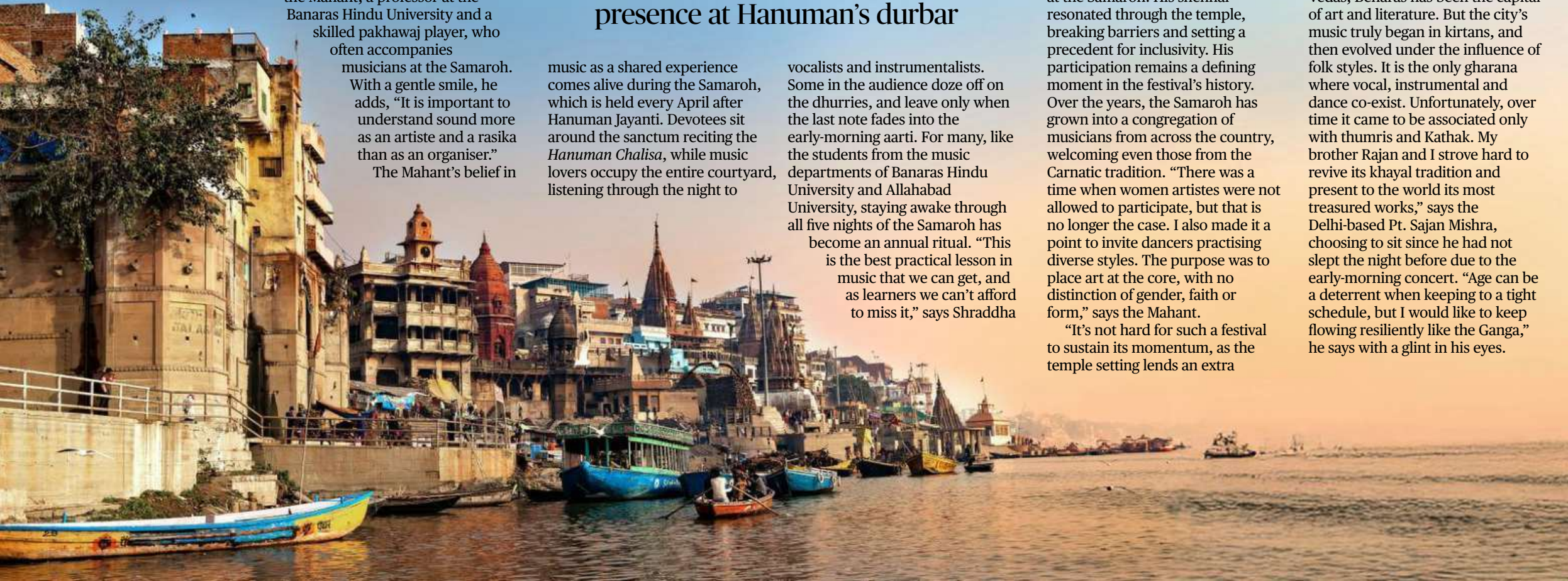
Sharma. Her friend, Abhishek Pandey, joins in: “The people of Benaras are known for their deep love of classical music, which is woven into their everyday life. Even those who may not grasp the finer nuances of raag and taal still connect with its emotional resonance. After all, the Benaras gharana is among the most influential traditions in Hindustani music.”

The conversation trails off as the students spot Mehtab Ali Niazi. As the young and talented sitarist, accompanied by the dynamic tabla artiste Ishaan Ghosh, rises from the stage after a riveting 90-minute rendition of raag Jaijaiwanti, the temple courtyard erupts in a cry of ‘Har Har Mahadev’. Mehtab responds with a warm namaskar – the exchange embodies the inclusive spirit of the Samaroh.

The Benaras-based Ustad Bismillah Khan became one of the earliest Muslim artistes to perform at the Samaroh. His shehnai resonated through the temple, breaking barriers and setting a precedent for inclusivity. His participation remains a defining moment in the festival’s history.

Over the years, the Samaroh has grown into a congregation of musicians from across the country, welcoming even those from the Carnatic tradition. “There was a time when women artistes were not allowed to participate, but that is no longer the case. I also made it a point to invite dancers practising diverse styles. The purpose was to place art at the core, with no distinction of gender, faith or form,” says the Mahant.

“It’s not hard for such a festival to sustain its momentum, as the temple setting lends an extra



Sreyashi Ghosh

Bickram Ghosh, tabla exponent and composer, takes Indian rhythm to the world stage as the artistic director of the India Pavilion at the 61st International Art Exhibition, La Biennale di Venezia 2026. The India Pavilion showcased ‘Many waters have flown’, a cross-cultural musical journey, conceived by Bickram. The programme weaves together diverse Indian musical traditions, each retaining its distinct identity while entering into a conversation with the others.

From accompanying Pt. Ravi Shankar and scoring music for over 55 films to four Grammy nominations, Bickram’s journey is a seamless blend of classical music and contemporary sound. He talks about his creative inspiration, his role at the Venice Biennale and what it truly means to put India on

Crossover sounds

As artistic director of the India Pavilion, tabla exponent Bickram Ghosh takes multi-genre Indian music to the Venice Biennale 2026

the global cultural map.

Question: Your early work, ‘Spirit of Kolkata’, was a synthesis of street noises, temple bells and everyday chatter. Did you plan to lend a similar sense of rootedness to your presentation at the Venice Biennale?

Answer: The ‘Spirit of Kolkata’ was an experimental track that drew on the sounds of the city. That was several years ago. I believe in staying connected to

my roots in everything I do. Quite like my albums, I am showcasing the rich tapestry of sounds and vocal genres of Indian music at the Biennale.

Q: How challenging is it to retain one’s artistic identity on a global platform?

A: With a strong classical foundation, it becomes easier to curate presentations for a global audience. But I had always wanted to be a versatile



musician, and that has helped me look beyond the classical format to come up with innovative rhythm patterns. Many of my musical outings,

including my stint as creative director of the Serendipity Festival for four consecutive years, have broadened my perspective. They gave me the

confidence to create and perform the kind of music that I truly enjoy.

Q: The India Pavilion at the Venice Biennale has been described as an experience of a lifetime, but the absence of local Italian artistes has also sparked some controversy. How do you respond to this?

A: The India Pavilion is meant to showcase India, and I don’t see any controversy in that. It is a platform for presenting India’s artistic voice, and that is precisely what is happening. I am presenting Indian music, and there has been tremendous interest among Italian audiences, who are genuinely eager to engage with it.

Q: Rhythmscape was a groundbreaking album, and now you have launched Rhythmscape 2.0. How far do you think listeners have come in terms of embracing fusion and experimentation?

A: I think audiences today are

far more open to fusion. People are increasingly comfortable with cultures overlapping, perhaps because they themselves are becoming cultural melting pots. We see this across food, clothing, music and cinema. I like to think of it as ‘glocal’ – where the global meets the local. There is a growing interest in hearing ethnic sounds on the world music stage, and when these traditions meet, they create a certain spiritual and melodic harmony.

Q: After the Venice Biennale, what next?

A: I am recording an album titled *Trikaala* with the legendary violinist L. Shankar from the original Shakti band and santoor exponent Pt. Tarun Bhattacharya. After the Venice Biennale, I head directly to Germany to work on multiple projects, including the ‘Tagore song cycle’ with the Duisburg Philharmonic Orchestra as part of a festival there.



Creative synergy Divya Devaguptapu with Ranjani Ramakrishnan and Vijay Natesan. PHOTO: M. SRINATH

interpretations of the swan: in the West, it denotes a final act (*swan song*), while in the East, the *Hamsa* signifies consciousness and freedom, reflected in the rhythm of breath – *ham* and *sa*, indicating self-realisation. Directed by Usha Rajeswari, the film explores themes of awareness, life and release, taking the iconic ballet *Dying Swan* as its conceptual point of departure.

In addition to workshops and lecture demonstrations, aimed at teaching music and dance, Divya and Ranjani have developed art retreats as part of their outreach. Their recent retreat, *Anunada*, held in San Felipe, B.C. Mexico, focused on the interconnectedness of *nāda*, *nātya*, and yoga. The sessions combined sound, movement and breath. Ranjani explored sound as vibration through tones, chants and natural rhythms; Divya guided movement as an inward-originating, outward-extending practice; while Carolyn Belko, a senior teacher from Iyengar Yoga, led breathwork and asana sessions.

Their latest offering is a studio in Chennai. It features a sprung dance floor, acoustic treatment and panelling, and a sound system that enables live music and multitrack recording. The studio also functions as an intimate performance space for presenting, streaming and recording Niyantri's works, including those in progress.

In a landscape where many classical dancers engage with interdisciplinary practices and extend their work beyond traditional performance, the ability to present one's artistic practice as a cohesive, tangible package becomes essential. Such articulation helps communicate the scope and relevance of their work to a wider audience, including those unfamiliar with the arts. This requires a careful balance: presenting work in a structured, accessible manner and conveying the depth of the artiste's skill and vision.

What stands out in Niyantri's approach is how Ranjani and Divya bring together their diverse initiatives with clarity and intent.

Charting a new course

Niyantri, an initiative that paves the way for collaborations and artistic practices beyond traditional confines

N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

Dancer Divya Devaguptapu and musician Ranjani Ramakrishnan have set out on a distinctive path, bringing their work together under a shared banner – Niyantri. A glimpse of the vision underpinning this initiative was revealed at its thoughtfully curated launch, held recently at the M.S. Subbulakshmi Auditorium at the Asian College of Journalism. The evening opened with a brief, evocative piece that foregrounded the dialogue between sound and movement – the resonant strains of the violin

intertwining with the rhythmic chime of the dancer's bells, enhanced by thoughtful lighting that underscored this audio-visual interplay. The central presentation, Tyagaraja's 'Chakkani raja margamu', was an imaginative interpretation: Divya delineated the 'royal path' through a trail of rose petals, using it as both a visual and conceptual anchor. Her engagement extended beyond choreography into the musical fabric itself, with a responsive, interpretive presence maintained through Ranjani's manodharma sections on the vocal and the tani avarthanam by mridangist Vijay Natesan. The concluding piece brought the violinist, dancer, mridangist, and lighting designers

(Charles and Dinesh) into a shared space, resulting in a fluid, spontaneous work. This finale effectively captured the underlying ethos of the presentation: a move towards immediacy and creative freedom, where dance unfolds in the moment rather than being overly premeditated. Divya and Ranjani, known for a series of collaborations, have consistently examined how their art, rooted in Carnatic music and Bharatanatyam, can extend beyond traditional confines to engage a wider audience. One of their key areas of engagement has been film. Their work, *Soham*, screened at international dance film festivals, draws upon contrasting

When theatre becomes a balancing act

J.C. Creations' latest play blends humour, suspense and a social message

Suganthv Krishnamachari

J.C. Creations' *Madhil Mel Poonaigal* (written and directed by V.P.S. Sriraman) tells the story of two young men, from different backgrounds. Venkatesh (Girish Venkat), from a middle-class family, is so shy that he avoids going to work, fearing he may have to interact with women in the office. His colleague Vasudha (Malini Devi) is determined to marry him because she thinks that he will be pliant. Gradually, he develops a liking for her. But her parents won't let her marry him, and Venkatesh is not bold enough to marry her in the face of parental objection. Prasanth (Sairasad Sriram), the son of a rich businessman, is



in love with Nithya (Vidhya Kannan) and wishes to marry her. While she wants to postpone the marriage, Prasanth's parents are not prepared to wait. With these complications, both men

are unable to marry the women they love. And Vasudha eventually marries Prasanth. Later, when she disappears, leaving behind a letter, the police detain both Prasanth and

Intriguing tale *Madhil Mel Poonaigal* was staged as part of KFA's Kodai Nataka Vizha at Narada Gana Sabha. PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Venkatesh for questioning. What happens to Vasudha is a mystery and the rest of the story revolves around it. *Madhil Mel Poonaigal* can neither be classified as a thriller nor a comedy, though it had its humorous moments. The play left one with many questions: How can a case of abduction be closed simply because the victim's family decides to pardon the abductor? At the end of the play, there came the inevitable message – learn to like what you get. Apart from other fine performances, Nanjil Revathi as Lalitha was impressive.

Story with a twist

Mazhaiyil Oor Iravu, staged at Kodai Nataka Vizha, impressed with its uncluttered script



Women power *Mazhaiyil Oor Iravu*. PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Suganthv Krishnamachari

Mazhaiyil Oor Iravu is the title of Theatrix Stage Crafters' play directed by S. Anand. The title suggests a thriller. While it isn't one in the strictest sense of the term, the story has some sleuthing by the hero and heroine. There is no murder or violent crime on the night when Anupama (Malini Devi) and Abhinav (Girish Venkat) are caught in the rain and are forced to take shelter in the house of author Agni (S. Anand). When Anupama discovers that the person who has given them refuge is the writer who once published

under the pseudonym of Agni, she is delighted, for she loves the feminist themes in his stories. Sadly, Agni had stopped writing years ago, and he explains the reason for that. His wife, Akila, eloped with her lover and later died. Shattered by the betrayal and her death, he stopped writing. Anupama wants to rekindle his lost spark of creativity, but a strange unease grips her. Though Agni's words seem harmless on the surface, they carry undertones of amorous intent. Has Anupama been misled by the tenor of his stories? Did Agni really seek to dismantle patriarchal structures as his stories suggest? Is Akila really dead?

Or is Agni a Janus-faced monster? The doubt lingers, and Anupama and Abhinav begin to probe his past. The playwright succeeded in creating and sustaining the momentum. As the scenes shifted back and forth from past to present, you could see the erosion of Agni's kind persona. While Akila (Nanjil Revathi) cowered in fright at ill-treatment, she fought back to save other women like Anupama from Agni. There were no flowery disquisitions on women. Apart from the uncluttered dialogue (by S. Gowrisankar), the play also stood out for strong performances by Malini Devi, Girish Venkat, Anand and Nanjil Revathi.

Play time

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha hosts the Mid-year drama festival from May 8 to 18 at 6.45 p.m. A series of Tamil plays will be staged at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar.
May 8: Komal Theatres' *Sivasankari*.
May 9: Three Enterains' *Kaattriniley Varum Geetham*, a bio-play on the legendary musician M.S. Subbulakshmi.
May 10: Dummies Drama's *Kapidhwaja*.
May 11: Koothapiran Navbharat Theatre's *Veera*.
May 12: J.C. Creations' *Madhi Mel Poonaigal*.
May 13: Theatre Marina's *The Miracles Of Guru Raghavendra Swami*.
May 14: PMG Mayurapriya's *Kallabhiramam*.
May 15: Legally Yours presents *Kudumpadaang*.
May 16: S. SRUUTHI's Naatya Naadha Nataka Sangamam's *Kandhan Karunaie*.
May 17: UAA's *Varadu Kutty - Paritchaikku Neramachu - 2*.
May 18: JB Cultural Foundation's *Maathru Devo Bhava*.

Songs from a rare string

Allam Durgaprasad's concert gave music lovers an opportunity to listen to the melodious atichitraveena



Musical ode Allam Durgaprasad's Tyagaraja Jayanti concert. PHOTO: M. SRINATH

P Srihari

The Chitraveena is an ancient instrument first referenced in sage Bharata's seminal treatise *Natya Sastra* two millennia ago. Sarangadeva's magnum opus *Sangita Ratnakara* also alludes to this string instrument. Over the past century, it has borne different nomenclatures such as Gottuvadyam, Chitravina itself, Atichitraveena, Navachitraveena and Vichitraveena, with the last one prevalent in North India. It brings forth the nuanced tapestry of Carnatic music with remarkable organicity – the interplay of plucking and sliding hands seamlessly weaving tonal vitality with the signature gamaka embellishments. Today, a handful of dedicated practitioners are striving to preserve its legacy and sustain its relevance, yet the instrument continues to navigate a precarious existence.

The Atichitraveena concert by senior exponent Allam Durgaprasad, organised recently by Sri Thiagaraja Sangeetha Vidwath Samajam, Mylapore, for Tyagaraja Jayanthi, assumes significance in this context. The recital reaffirmed the instrument's innate affinity for exploring the quintessential idioms and ethos of Carnatic music. It was built on the strength of popular kritis, melodic appeal, leisurely kalapramanam and a fine synergy with the co-artistes Usha Rajagopalan (violin) and B. Ganapathyraman (mridangam).

Durgaprasad commenced with the Kalyani Adi tala varnam 'Vanajakshiro' by Poochi Srinivasa Iyengar. Clear phrases marked the short Malayamarutam raga essay leading into 'Manasa etulortune' set to Rupaka tala. In this kriti, Tyagaraja admonishes the mind not to waste time but chant the 'Rama nama'. The ultra-slow tempo – not usually employed for this kriti – and gamaka-laden sangatis offered a different listening experience. The swara passages at the pallavi opening were languid, yet expressive, following a brief shift to a brisker pace often adopted in the charanam. The iconic 'Nada tanum

anisanam', in Chittaranjani – a nishada-antya raga derived from Kharaharapriya – unfolded in all its solemnity. 'Teliyaleru rama' in Dhenuka poignantly conveyed Tyagaraja's pity for those oblivious to the virtue of piety and the path of devotion. Raga Gowrimanohari was delineated in some detail, with both Durgaprasad and Usha adeptly distilling its essence. 'Guruleka etuvanti' in Khanda Chapu, where Tyagaraja emphasises the indispensability of a guru's grace, was played neatly, followed by kalpanaswaras on the pallavi line.

'Sobillu saptaswara' in Jagannamohini-Rupaka, another famous kriti extolling the glory of the musical notes, served as a pace-setter ahead of the main suite, Pantuvareli (Kamavardhini). The 51st Melakarta raga can evoke varied moods and Durgaprasad rightly chose to present its contemplative facet, considering the song that followed. Particularly striking were the measured sancharas traversing an octave and the fast-paced phrases towards the end. Usha's response on the violin was an extension of the evocative arc. 'Siva siva siva yenaraada' stands as a rarity within Tyagaraja's oeuvre. If his devotional outpourings are akin to a mighty river, then Rama bhakti can be likened to its main channel and salutations to other deities to its tributaries.

The composition is an outlier in another sense too – the opening lines of the pallavi, anupallavi and charanam share identical melodic contours. On an instrument, bereft of lyrics and vocal inflection, that sameness and repetition can induce ennui – a pitfall that a vocalist is likely to avoid. Another moot point is the suitability of an instrumental recital for a composer's commemorative concert. Returning to the concert, an engaging swara segment gave way to a concise tani avarthanam in Adi tala by Ganapathyraman, who lent a good hand throughout.

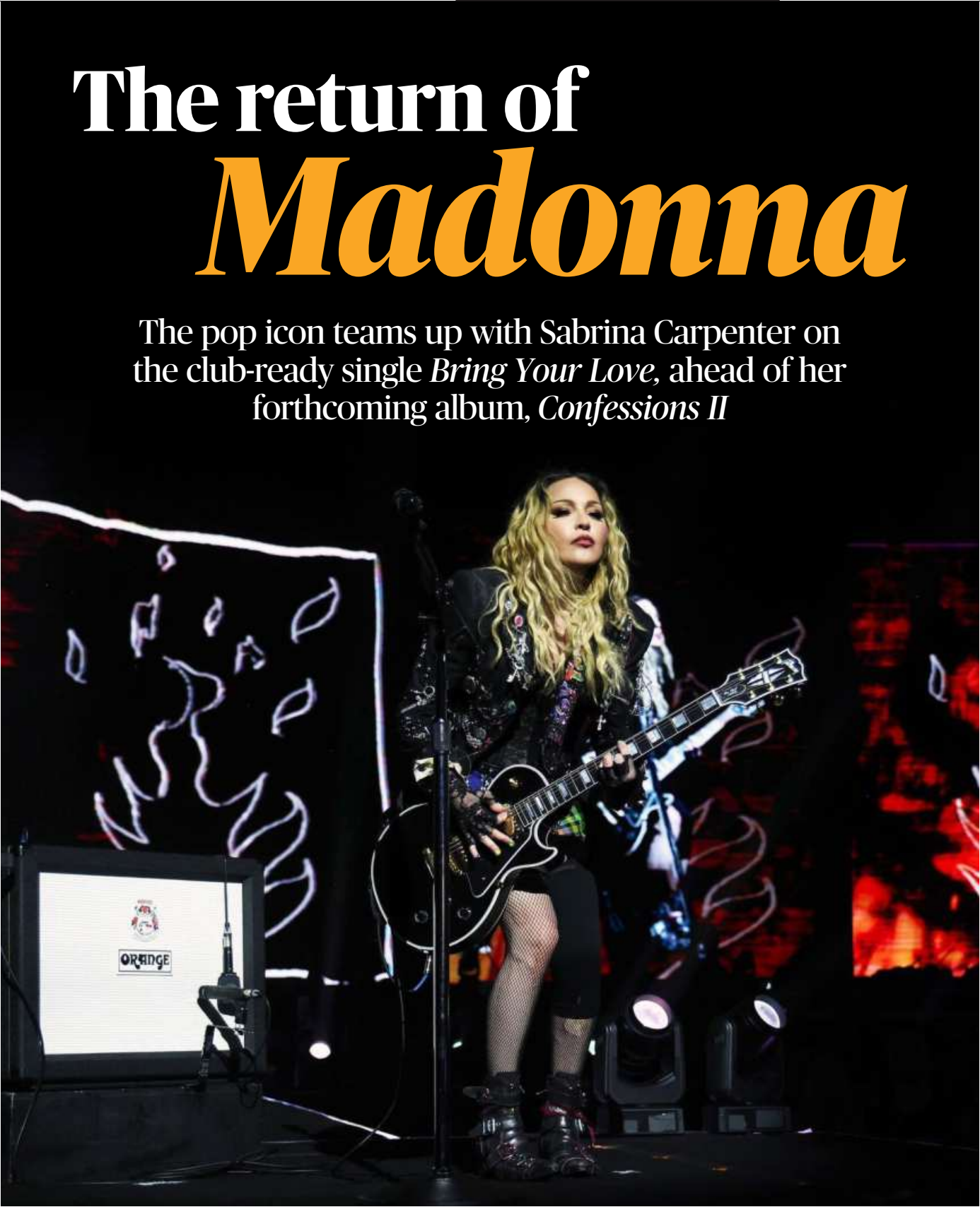
The concert concluded with 'Meevalla gunadoshamemi' in Kapi-Khanda Chapu, a stirring exhortation to embrace one's flaws rather than deflect blame.

N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

Madonna once said, “Michael is gone. Tupac is gone. Prince is gone. Whitney is gone. Amy Winehouse is gone. David Bowie is gone. But I’m still standing”. Now, in 2026, as the final titan of that era, she reclaims her title as the Queen of Pop with ‘I Feel So Free’, a high-energy single that sets the stage for her upcoming *Confessions* sequel.

Nearly 11 years after her last appearance, Madonna returned to the Coachella stage for a surprise guest spot during Sabrina Carpenter’s headlining set this year. Hailed as a ‘full-circle moment,’ the performance marked the 20th anniversary of her legendary 2006 debut in the Sahara Tent. She performed a four-song mini-set that bridged her legacy with her upcoming 2026 album, *Confessions on a Dance Floor: Part II*. It featured *Bring Your Love*, a powerful duet with Sabrina.

Madonna’s catalogue isn’t just fading into the background; it has become the backbone of modern storytelling. Over the last five years, she has staged a ‘renaissance by proxy,’ with her biggest hits hijacked by streaming giants to do the emotional heavy lifting. Stranger Things utilised ‘Material Girl’ and ‘Angel’ to anchor its 1980s aesthetic, sparking a TikTok-led ‘Material Gworl’ era for Gen Z. Then came the 2024 Marvel juggernaut *Deadpool & Wolverine*, which weaponised ‘Like a Prayer’ for high-octane action, sending the gospel-infused anthem screaming back onto the global charts. Now, with her biopic evolving into a Netflix series, the raw energy of ‘Lucky Star’



The pop icon teams up with Sabrina Carpenter on the club-ready single *Bring Your Love*, ahead of her forthcoming album, *Confessions II*

and ‘Burning Up’ is surging once more.

Madonna’s enduring relevance is rooted in a career-long refusal to blink in the face of authority, turning pop music into a stage for social and religious provocation. In 1986, ‘Papa Don’t Preach’ ignited a firestorm by handing agency to a pregnant teenager. ‘Like a Prayer,’ in 1989, led Pope John Paul II to call for a global boycott of the singer. By 1992, she pushed the boundaries of the permissible even further; the *Erotica* album and her notorious *Sex* book were nearly universally condemned, yet they were years ahead of their time in championing sexual liberation and queer visibility. *American Life* saw her being blacklisted from the U.S. radio in 2003. Yet, Madonna transformed from a mere ‘Material Girl’ into a high-priestess of subversion, who turned scandals into highpoints of pop history.

Madonna’s genius lies in her ability to shed her skin just as the world thinks it has pinned her down. In the late 1990s, she traded her leather corsets for the ‘Earth Mother’ aesthetic of the *Ray of Light* era, fundamentally shifting the global zeitgeist. With the release of ‘Frozen,’ she

replaced structured hairspray with witchy, dark locks and billowing Jean Paul Gaultier gowns, transforming from a pop star into a desert sorceress. This wasn’t just a costume change; it was a cultural bridge. By sporting intricate mehndi designs in her visuals and performing ‘Shanti/Ashtangi’ at the MTV VMAs, she single-handedly brought Eastern philosophy and Boho-chic into the mainstream. Madonna became the unofficial face of Ashtanga Yoga, proving through her own physique that what was once a niche ‘hippie’ activity was actually a rigorous, elite discipline. By treating her identity as an ever-evolving work of art, Madonna has turned the act of reinvention into her greatest survival tactic – ensuring that while trends may flicker and fade, her ability to mirror and then manipulate the cultural moment keeps her perpetually at the centre of the frame.

In a generation obsessed with optimising every second, where music is often chopped into 30-second clips or shuffled into flavourless, algorithm-driven playlists, Madonna remains a defiant architect of the long-form album. While today’s landscape favours the disposable single, her career was built on cohesive bodies of work such as *True Blue* or *Confessions on a Dance Floor* – records designed to be experienced as a singular, atmospheric journey rather than a collection of scattered hits. This commitment to her craft allows her to shatter the glass ceiling of ageism.

Madonna represents a rare class of generational artistes whose career serves as the blueprint for the modern pop icon, ensuring her influence remains a permanent fixture rather than a historical footnote.

While today’s landscape favours the disposable single, her career was built on cohesive bodies of work such as *True Blue* or *Confessions on a Dance Floor* — records designed to be experienced as a singular, atmospheric journey rather than a collection of scattered hits.

CALENDAR

Part-time music courses

The Music Academy invites applications for part-time classes in vocal and instrumental music to be held at its premises. The vocal course, for beginners, is spread over four years, and is held twice in a week. Those who can sing varnams can join in the third year. The instrumental music course (mridangam, veena and violin), spanning four years, will also be held twice weekly. The faculty members are: Sweta Balasubramanian and N. Subasri (vocal); Padma Murali and Shobhana Swaminathan (veena); Usha Rajagopalan and Pavani Mallajosyula (violin) and S.J. Arjun Ganesh (mridangam). Applications will be available at the Academy’s office from today. Last date is June 6. For details call 044-2811 2231 or 2811 5162.

Tribute to Tagore

A pan-India tribute to Rabindranath Tagore, as part of his 165th birth anniversary celebrations, will be held on May 10, 5 p.m. at RJ Auditorium, Sathyabama University. A synchronised chorus featuring more than 100 singers has been organised to mark the occasion. Titled ‘Shoto Kontthe Sohoso Konttho’, it is a saangeet Bharati Muktdadhara initiative, conceived and directed by Arundhati Deb. For details call 044-48541213 or 24451395.

Evening of music

Narada Gana Sabha Trust presents Nadasangamam - (Talent Promotion Concerts) on May 13 at 5.30 p.m. The evening opens with a vocal recital by Preethi and Mahathi, accompanied by R. Srikrithi (violin) and PVS Balaji Yuvaraj (mridangam). At 7 p.m., there will be a vocal recital by Jyothiradithya, with Bhargava Vignesh (violin) and Ajeet Sridhar (mridangam).

Tirtha compositions

The Music Academy features Sumitra Vasudev’s vocal concert, themed on Narayana Tirtha compositions, today 6 p.m. at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. She will be accompanied by Usha Rajagopalan (violin) and B. Ganapathyraman (mridangam). The programme has been organised under the endowment instituted by P. Obul Reddy and P. Gnanamba.

Festive offering

The Vidyatri utsavam taking place at Arulmigu Parthasarathyswami Temple, Triplicane, will feature a series of concerts and discourse from May 11 to 17 at 7 p.m. Schedule: May 11: S. Aishwarya and S. Soundarya. May 12: S. Mahathi. May 13: Trichur Brothers. May 14: K. Bharat Sundar. May 15: A. Kanyakumari, Rajeev Mukundan and Sivateja (violin). May 16: Vishakha Hari. May 17: Sandeep Narayan.

Viswa shanti utsavam

The punaravarthana mandalabisheka viswa shanti mahotsavam at Sri Varasiddhi Vinayakar Sri Panchamukha Anjaneyar temple, Gowriwakkam, will take place on May 10 beginning with special Thirumanjanam at 8.30 a.m. and concluding with the shanti homam at 10.30 a.m.

Narendra Kusnur

Getting ready for a fresh round of rehearsals, Bruce Guthrie talks of his latest play – *Death and the Maiden*. “It’s a clever play, with many subtle references, and that’s what drew me to it. It’s darkly funny, and has plenty of gallows humour. But it’s definitely not a comedy, and it raises a lot of pertinent issues,” he says.

Premiered in 1990, *Death and the Maiden* was written by Ariel Dorfman, an Argentine-Chilean playwright, whose theme was based on events that took place in Chile during and after the military regime of Augusto Pinochet. It depicts the association between a political prisoner – Paulina Salas, her husband Gerardo, and doctor Roberto Miranda – who she believes tortured her in the past though he never showed his face. Though Augusto isn’t named, Bruce says the play is set during the time a new democratic government took over.

The play features Ira Dubey as Paulina, Vivek Gomber as her husband and Neil Bhoopalam as the doctor. It will be staged at the Experimental Theatre of the National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA) on May 9 and 10.

The head of theatre and films at NCPA, Bruce Guthrie has earlier directed four plays during his stint in India – Nick Payne’s *Constellations* with two different sets of lead performers, Simon Stephens’ monologue *Sea Wall*, Tom Stoppard’s *Every Good Boy Deserves Favour* and Conor McPherson’s *St Nicholas*.

Bruce believes in retaining the original script to the largest extent. “I believe that theatre is writer-led. As a director, I am just the conveyor, and help actors in the expression of the script. I also don’t believe in making too many changes after the first run. I keep observing people in the hall and have an understanding of their response. But I retain what the writer says, and am not tempted to change just to please the audience,” he shares.

The director says he has admired *Death and the Maiden* for years and adds: “Ira



Ira Dubey and Neil Bhoopalam with Vivek Gomber, who portrays the doctor.

Bruce says the play is set during the time when many people with communist leanings were arrested. He explains, “It was all related to Cuban leader Fidel Castro and that era, and central and Latin America. People were taken to facilities and tortured in the name of political prisoners. Ariel Dorfman was in exile for a number of years, and observed the situation closely. Paulina is thus shown as one of those victims.”

The director says Dorfman’s writing is somewhat akin to German playwright Bertolt Brecht before the Second World War. “Brecht’s plays take potshots not only at war but also at the Nazi regime. Dorfman makes use of a similar theme, but in a different region and period, against another dictatorship,” he says.

Three issues are brought up in *Death and the Maiden*. Bruce explains. “The first is whether a country can move on after such a brutal regime; second is the equation between the wife and her husband. Can they move on from earlier events and are those events and timelines independent of each other? The third is the question of justice vs vengeance and whether they can be the same thing.”

The play’s title is inspired by Austrian composer Franz Schubert’s string quartet ‘Death and the Maiden’. It’s a piece Paulina heard while being tortured, and is something that disturbs her each time. While musicians from the Symphony Orchestra of India will play these parts, the other music has been composed by Andrew T. Mackay, known for theatrical productions of *Henry V* and *Life Of Pi*.

Bruce Guthrie will decide on future staging plans once the first run is over. He believes in having as many runs in the first few months, and as such has no intention of reviving his older plays such as *Constellations* and *Every Good Boy Deserves Favour*. At the moment his focus is on *Death and the Maiden*, besides other projects produced by NCPA.

A classic reimaged

Ariel Dorfman’s *Death and the Maiden* returns to the stage under Bruce Guthrie’s direction

approached me about it more than a year ago, and I was excited to have the opportunity to work with her on this text. She is an actress with an incredible capacity for intense, emotional roles, especially in plays which have strong female leads. Vivek Gomber is an actor whom I have admired for some time now, following his excellent performance in Harold Pinter’s *Betrayal*. Neil and I collaborated on *Every Good Boy Deserves Favour*, and

he’s a fantastic actor.”

Besides being known as one of the landmark political plays of the late 20th century, *Death and the Maiden* was also converted by filmmaker Roman Polanski into a 1994 movie starring Sigourney Weaver, Ben Kingsley and Stuart Wilson. According to Bruce, while the film has a clear-cut ending, the play concludes ambiguously and is open to different interpretations. “But that is the beauty of theatre,” he says.



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BRUCE GUTHRIE



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